

SECTION TEN

LANGUAGE & COMMUNICATION

Shared language creates understanding. Language barriers force vulnerability and trust. And in romantasy, language does more than move information around. It reveals power, creates secrets, enables private communication, and forces characters to truly listen to each other.

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question below will apply to your story. If your characters share a language, skip the barrier sections and focus on voice, silence, and private communication. If literacy isn't relevant, skip it entirely. Start with what creates the most tension between your specific characters and build outward from there.

The Bridge & Barrier Principle

Every word your characters learn in each other's language is a brick in a bridge. Every silence is a wall. Only language is a worldbuilding element that serves as both an obstacle between your characters and the tool that will allow them to conquer that obstacle.

Most romantasy barriers are external. Political alliances, forbidden magic, rival courts. But language barriers are different because they live inside every interaction. Every conversation becomes an act of trust. Every misunderstanding is a small wound. Every time your character learns a new word in their partner's language it is an act of investment that says: *your world matters enough for me to learn how you see it.*

This is why language works so powerfully in romance. It doesn't just create a problem to be solved. It creates a gradient of intimacy. Your characters move from strangers who can't communicate, to halting exchanges, to fluency, to private words only they share, to silence that says everything. This progression of building intimacy parallels the process of falling in love. In *ACOTAR*, Feyre's willingness to lower her mental walls for Rhysand's daemati link is a stronger declaration of love than any verbal confession could be. To allow someone to enter your mind and thoughts is to give up the last vestige of control. That's the bridge, fully built.

Build language that creates both barriers and bridges. Make your characters work to understand each other, and make that work meaningful.

Where does your story sit on the barrier-to-bridge progression?

Language intimacy builds in stages. Where do your characters start, and where do they end? Mark the stages that appear in your story — these become scenes to write.

STAGE	PRESENT IN YOUR STORY?	WHEN IT HAPPENS
<i>Can't communicate at all — gestures, frustration, misreading</i>	<i>Yes — Chapters 1–4, when Feyre first arrives in Prythian and can't read the Fae language on signs or documents</i>	<i>Early meetings, before any trust is built</i>
Halting exchanges — single words, pointing, stumbling		
Functional communication — can get through a conversation but miss nuance		
Real conversation — can argue, joke, confess		
Private language — words, signals, or codes only they share		

STAGE	PRESENT IN YOUR STORY?	WHEN IT HAPPENS
Silence that says everything – words no longer needed		

Language as a Romantic Toolkit

Most writers think about language as a single tool: the language barrier. But language actually gives you a whole toolkit of romantic dynamics, each creating a different flavour of tension. The real craft is matching the right language pattern to the emotional beat you need.

LANGUAGE PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES FOR ROMANCE
Language barrier	Characters can't communicate freely	Vulnerability, forced trust, slow-burn intimacy through learning
Private language	Words, codes, or signals only they share	Exclusivity, a world that belongs to just them
Code-switching	Characters speak differently in different contexts	Hidden selves revealed; hearing their "real" voice becomes intimate
Silence	What goes unsaid between them	Tension, longing, the weight of unspoken feeling
Language learning	One teaches, one learns	Investment, patience, power dynamics, care made visible

LANGUAGE PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES FOR ROMANCE
Translation	A third party mediates their words	Vulnerability, potential manipulation, longing to speak directly
Accent/dialect	How they sound marks who they are	Class tension, belonging vs. outsider status, attraction to difference
True names	Names that carry power or vulnerability	Ultimate trust, giving someone power over you

The key question isn't *what languages exist in your world*. It's this: what language barriers exist between your characters? What private communication methods do they develop? And what does learning each other's language mean for intimacy?

Character Pairings with Built-In Linguistic Tension

PAIRING DYNAMIC	LANGUAGE CREATES...	EXAMPLE
Conqueror / conquered	The dominant language erases the other's; learning the "lesser" tongue is an act of respect or rebellion	Jude in <i>The Cruel Prince</i> , a human raised speaking Fae, fluent in a tongue that belongs to her captors
Court noble / commoner	"Proper" vs. "common" speech; code-switching reveals which world they belong in	Sophie in <i>An Offer from a Gentleman</i> , whose refined accent makes Benedict suspicious she's not really a maid
Different species/realms	Fundamentally different communication; magic, gesture, or empathy bridges the gap	Feyre and Rhysand in <i>ACOTAR</i> , where the daemati mind-link bypasses spoken language entirely

PAIRING DYNAMIC	LANGUAGE CREATES...	EXAMPLE
Scholar / illiterate	Power imbalance in written communication; teaching becomes intimate or condescending	Penelope in <i>Romancing Mister Bridgerton</i> , whose secret writing life as Whistledown gives her power Colin never suspected
Spy / mark	Language as weapon; fluency is deception, and the truth of accent or mother tongue slips out under pressure	Casteel in <i>From Blood and Ash</i> , who poses as “Hawke” so convincingly that Poppy falls in love with a persona

Which language patterns create the most tension between your characters?

Look at the toolkit table above. Pick the 2–3 patterns most relevant to your romance. For each one, note the specific scene or dynamic it creates.

LANGUAGE PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS BETWEEN YOUR CHARACTERS	A SCENE IT CREATES
<i>Language barrier</i>	<i>Feyre can't read — Rhysand teaches her, creating private tutoring sessions that become intimate</i>	<i>The reading lessons in ACOTAR where proximity + patience = attraction</i>

Common Mistakes with Language

Mistake #1: The Rosetta Stone Problem

Characters who couldn't communicate in Chapter 3 are having nuanced arguments by Chapter 8 with no real learning period in between. Language learning is one of the best slow-burn tools you have. Skipping it robs you of dozens of intimate scenes: the fumbling, the pointing, the laughter at mistakes, the first time they understand each other without help.

FIX

Map language acquisition to your romance arc. Early chapters should be gestures, single words, misunderstandings. Middle chapters bring halting conversations and breakthrough moments. Late chapters unlock fluency, private jokes, and the ability to wound with words because they finally know how. In *Fourth Wing*, the psychic bond between Violet and Xaden builds gradually through overlapping dragon bonds, starting as an involuntary tingle and escalating to full sensory sharing. It works because each new level of connection arrives alongside a new level of emotional risk.

Mistake #2: The Babel Dump

Three pages of linguistic history, twelve named languages with grammar notes, a pronunciation guide, and none of it matters to the plot. Readers don't need a linguistics degree. They need to feel the friction of miscommunication and the relief of understanding.

FIX

Build only the language that serves your story. If your protagonist speaks two languages, we need to feel the difference between them, not read a textbook about either.

Mistake #3: The Silent Treatment

Treating silence as the absence of communication rather than a form of it. Characters who don't talk simply... don't communicate. Silence is one of the most powerful communication tools in romance. Comfortable silence signals safety. Tense silence signals unspoken desire or unresolved conflict. Ignoring silence means missing half of how your characters actually relate to each other. **Quick self-check: are you making any of these mistakes?** | Mistake | Am I At Risk? | What I'll Do Instead || —||—|| The Rosetta Stone Problem — characters learn each other's language too fast |||| The Babel Dump — too much linguistic worldbuilding that doesn't serve the plot ||| The Silent Treatment — silence treated as absence rather than communication |||

FIX

Write silence as deliberately as you write dialogue. What does each silence mean? What is each character not saying, and why?

Languages in Your World

The linguistic landscape of your world determines what's possible between your characters. A world with one universal language has different romantic stakes than one where every kingdom speaks a different tongue. The question isn't how many languages exist. It's what barriers and bridges those languages create.

How many languages exist in your world?

One universal language? Many regional languages? Hundreds of dialects? The answer shapes how easily your characters can connect.

YOUR ANSWER

What are the major languages?

Think about who speaks each language, its cultural prestige, and whether knowing it grants access or marks someone as an outsider.

LANGUAGE	WHO SPEAKS IT	STATUS
<i>Common Tongue</i>	<i>Everyone in the human kingdoms; traders from other realms</i>	<i>Common: the language of commerce and daily life; considered unsophisticated by nobles</i>
<i>High Fae</i>	<i>The Fae courts; human scholars and diplomats who've studied it</i>	<i>Prestigious: spoken at court; magical contracts must be written in it to be binding</i>

Status options: common, prestigious, forbidden, sacred, trade, etc.

Is there a common/trade language most people speak?

What does using this language signal about a speaker? Does your protagonist rely on it or resist it?

YOUR ANSWER

Are there trade pidgins or mixed languages?

Languages that developed from contact between groups often carry stories of conquest, trade, or migration in their vocabulary. A character who speaks a pidgin language might be marked as someone who lives between worlds, which is its own kind of romantic identity.

YOUR ANSWER

Multilingual Spaces

Where languages mix, characters are most exposed. Markets, courts, border towns, and ports are pressure cookers where communication is constant negotiation. Code-switching? Sticking to trade language? Relying on translators? How your characters handle multilingual environments reveals confidence, adaptability, and social intelligence, all of which are attractive qualities on the page. A character who moves fluently between languages carries a different kind of appeal than one who struggles.

Where do your characters encounter multilingual environments, and how do they navigate them?

Multilingual spaces — markets, courts, border towns — force characters to negotiate communication in real time. How your character handles that reveals confidence, vulnerability, and adaptability, all of which the other character will notice.

LOCATION	LANGUAGES PRESENT	HOW YOUR PROTAGONIST NAVIGATES	HOW YOUR LOVE INTEREST NAVIGATES	WHAT THE OTHER NOTICES
<i>The Night Court's starfall celebration — Fae, Illyrian, and High Fae all spoken</i>	<i>High Fae (formal), Illyrian (among warriors), Common (servants)</i>	<i>Feyre sticks to Common but catches fragments of Illyrian; feels excluded</i>	<i>Rhysand code-switches effortlessly between all three; translates for Feyre without being asked</i>	<i>Feyre notices how naturally Rhysand moves between worlds — it makes him feel both unreachable and protective</i>

Language Barriers Between Characters

If your characters don't share a first language, you've got built-in tension, and one of the most effective slow-burn devices in romantasy. Every conversation requires effort. Every new word learned is a gift. Every misunderstanding is a small crisis that forces them closer or pushes them apart.

Protagonist's Languages

How did they learn each one? What doors does their linguistic knowledge open or close?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Native language	
Other languages and fluency	
How they learned each one	
What doors their languages open or close	

Love Interest's Languages

Do they share a language with the protagonist, or will communication itself become part of their journey together?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Native language	
Other languages and fluency	
How they learned each one	
What doors their languages open or close	

Do they share a common language when they first meet?

If not, how do they communicate initially? Gestures? A shared third language? Magic? And if they do share a language, is it native to both of them, or is one always slightly at a disadvantage?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Do they share a language at first meeting?	

ASPECT	DETAILS
If yes — is one at a disadvantage in it?	
If no — how do they communicate initially?	
What's lost in this early communication?	

Who learns whose language?

This is a power question as much as a practical one. Does one teach the other? Do they meet in the middle? Does the love interest learn the protagonist's "lesser" language as an act of respect?

YOUR ANSWER

Translators & Interpreters

When characters need translation, a third party enters their most intimate space. Someone else hears every word, controls meaning, and stands between two people trying to reach each other. That's vulnerability and story opportunity in one.

Do your characters ever need a translator?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Who translates	
How trustworthy are they	

What can't be said through a translator?

What's too private, too dangerous, or too intimate to say through a third party? The things they can't say with someone listening become the things they long to say alone.

YOUR ANSWER

When can they finally communicate without help?

What changes when the translator is no longer needed? This is often a turning point: the first time they're truly alone in conversation.

YOUR ANSWER

Does the translator have their own agenda?

Could they mistranslate? Report what they hear? Manipulate the relationship? A translator with their own motives adds a layer of tension to every exchange.

YOUR ANSWER

The Intimacy of Language Learning

Teaching someone your language is one of the most intimate things you can do. You're giving them access to your world, your thoughts, the way you name things. And learning someone's language is an act of surrender. You sound foolish, you make mistakes, you become vulnerable. Both of these are gold for romance.

What does teaching or learning language reveal about them?

Patience? Intelligence? Cultural values? Playfulness? Frustration? How someone teaches, and how someone learns, reveals character as clearly as any action scene.

YOUR ANSWER

The Protagonist's First Word

First words carry weight. Is it practical, accidental, or something that reveals character?

ASPECT	DETAILS
The word	
What it means	

ASPECT	DETAILS
Context of learning it	

The Love Interest's First Word

What does their choice to learn this particular word reveal about what they notice or value?

ASPECT	DETAILS
The word	
What it means	
Context of learning it	

When can they first have a real conversation?

What changes when they can finally understand each other fully, when the bridge is built enough to carry the weight of real meaning?

YOUR ANSWER

Multilingual Dialogue on the Page

If the characters in your writing speak multiple languages, you will have an immediate, practical writing problem: how do you actually represent that on the page? English-language fantasy has developed a reliable toolkit for this, and the key is choosing the technique that matches the emotional experience you want your reader to have.

The Translation Contract

You need to establish your contract with the reader before you write a single line of multilingual dialogue. Will they be reading literal English? English that stands in for another language? A translated in-world document? If you make your decision early, you won't have to negotiate that with the reader every time you add a new language to the mix.

Naomi Novik uses culturally specific terms and proper nouns ("the Staryk," "tsar") to give a sense of linguistic atmosphere in *Spinning Silver*, but she keeps the reader processing at the sentence level entirely in English. The reader feels a world shaped by other languages without having to decode the page. R.F. Kuang took a different approach in *The Poppy War*. She provides a definition for unfamiliar terms when they appear for the first time ("Keju" is defined immediately after it appeared), then later uses can drop the explanation because the reader's already learned it.

Both approaches work beautifully. Your only job is to determine which one works best for your story.

Your Toolkit

You don't need to pick just one technique. Most successful multilingual fantasy combines several, but keeps each term on a consistent track: first occurrence handled one way, later occurrences another.

TECHNIQUE	HOW IT WORKS	BEST FOR	WATCH OUT FOR
Untranslated word + inline gloss	Foreign term followed by a brief explanation: "Keju, the Empire-wide exam"	Introducing key cultural terms with zero friction	Over-glossing; if every paragraph has a new term with scaffolding, the prose reads like a textbook

TECHNIQUE	HOW IT WORKS	BEST FOR	WATCH OUT FOR
Language tag with English rendering	“He answered in Divasti, voice flat. ‘You don’t belong here.’“	High clarity while preserving multilingual reality; especially useful when the POV character doesn’t understand	Can feel clinical if overused; vary with other techniques
Context-only inference	Meaning never explicitly defined; the reader deduces it from action, repetition, or consequences	Creating mystery, atmosphere, or the feeling of being an outsider	Frustrating if the reader needs the meaning to follow the plot; best for texture, not critical plot information
Staged comprehension	A phrase appears untranslated, the character senses partial meaning, then a mediator translates	Revelations, turning points, moments where understanding changes everything	Requires setup; the “I almost understood” beat needs to feel earned, not arbitrary
Magical translation with slippage	A spell or device translates, but imperfectly: humour is lost, insults arrive as compliments, poetry flattens	Preserving linguistic difference while keeping characters communicable; creates comedy and tension from mistranslation	If the translation always works perfectly, you’ve eliminated one of your best tension tools

S.A. Chakraborty employs untranslated Divasti phrases and a narrator who tells us “I do not speak Divasti,” and thus forces a shift to accented common language in *The City of Brass*. Untranslated Divasti

phrases indicate exclusion. The accented lingua franca marks partial inclusion. We always know who holds the power and who is accommodating whom.

Staged Comprehension as Romance Pacing

Here's something worth playing with: in romantasy, the reader's understanding of a language can mirror the protagonist's understanding of the love interest. There is a pattern to follow: withhold meaning, indicate meaning through tone and body language, and confirm meaning at an emotionally significant time.

This is the structure of a slow-burn reveal. At the beginning of a romance, foreign words are opaque. Both the reader and the protagonist are locked out. As intimacy develops, context clues accumulate, and the moment of complete translation will usually coincide with the moment of full emotional understanding.

Kuang goes a step further in *Babel*: translation itself is the magic system, and the energy comes from what's *lost* between languages, turning semantic gaps into literal power. Mistranslation isn't just an error. It's productive.

Most of our fantasy stories have used the following format: the first instance of a word or phrase is glossed, and all subsequent instances depend upon the reader remembering, key emotional utterances are completely translated, and minor background chatter remains untranslated.

Map a staged comprehension moment for your story.

Pick a word or phrase from the love interest's language that will become significant. Plan how the reader's understanding of it builds alongside the protagonist's.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS	CHAPTER/SCENE
<i>Opaque — the word appears, meaning unknown</i>	<i>Rhysand says “mate” in the Old Language; Feyre doesn’t understand it, and neither does the reader</i>	<i>Early encounter — the word is atmospheric, not yet meaningful</i>
Partial — context clues suggest the meaning		

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS	CHAPTER/SCENE
Full — the word is translated at an emotional peak		
Echo — the word returns in a new context, meaning transformed		

How does the full meaning of this word change the relationship?

The best staged comprehension moments don't just deliver a translation — they reframe everything the character thought they understood. The word hasn't changed; the character has.

YOUR ANSWER

The Universal Translator Trap

If your world has magical translation (a spell, an artefact, a telepathic bond), you need to be very careful not to make the solution to the problem too perfect. If you create a magical device that always provides the correct translation, you remove all the possibilities for misunderstandings, eliminate reasons for characters to learn each other's languages, and create a sense of interchangeability among multilingual cultures.

One way to avoid this is to add at least one constraint.

CONSTRAINT	WHAT IT DOES FOR YOUR STORY
Cost (fatigue, lifespan, debt)	Translation becomes a sacrifice, not a convenience
Domain limits (works on speech but not texts, or vice versa)	Characters still need each other for certain kinds of understanding
Register loss (humour, poetry, prayer, and insult don't translate)	The most emotionally charged moments are the ones the magic can't handle
Unreliability (fails under stress, mishears near-synonyms)	Creates tension at exactly the moments it matters most
Power asymmetry (one side controls the translator)	Translation becomes political, not neutral
Intimacy gating (only bonded lovers can "hear" thoughts)	The translation itself becomes a marker of relationship depth

If your world has magical translation, what breaks it?

Perfect translation kills tension. Pick at least one constraint from the table above and describe how it affects your characters' communication.

CONSTRAINT YOU'RE USING	HOW IT FAILS AT THE WORST MOMENT	WHAT YOUR CHARACTERS DO INSTEAD
<i>Register loss — the daemati bond can't transmit humour or sarcasm</i>	<i>Feyre sends a sarcastic thought; Rhysand receives it as flat hostility and pulls away</i>	<i>She has to explain she was joking — vulnerability through having to narrate her own tone</i>

Your Approach

How do you represent other languages on the page?

Which technique (or combination) matches the experience you want readers to have?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Primary technique	
How foreign words are formatted (italics, roman, tags)	
How much the reader understands vs. the protagonist	

Does your world have magical translation?

If so, what are its limits? What can't it translate? What happens when it fails?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Translation method	
What it can't handle	
When it fails (and what that costs)	

Voice, Accent & How They Sound

Beyond what they say, what do they *sound* like? Voice is one of the most visceral markers of attraction. The way someone's accent shifts when they're emotional, the rough edge when they're angry, the softening when they say your name. These details make readers feel the chemistry in their bones.

What do your characters sound like?

Think beyond pitch. Consider texture, rhythm, what emotions colour their speech, and how the other person experiences hearing them.

VOICE ASPECT	PROTAGONIST	LOVE INTEREST
<i>Pitch, texture, quality</i>		
<i>What the other notices about it</i>		
<i>How it changes with emotion</i>		
<i>What their name sounds like in this voice</i>		

When does voice convey more than words?

The catch in their throat? The softening when they say the other's name? The way their voice changes when angry, aroused, afraid?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a moment when one recognises the other by voice alone?

In darkness, across a room, through a door:

YOUR ANSWER

Accents, Dialects & Class Markers

The space between how two people talk can have just as much tension as the space between their social classes. Accents and dialects are identity markers, and in romantasy they do double duty: they tell the reader who this character is, and they show the love interest what draws or divides them.

In *An Offer from a Gentleman*, Benedict Bridgerton is fascinated by Sophie's refined accent because it doesn't match her role as a housemaid. The fact that her way of speaking identifies her as being out of place is what keeps him interested enough to continue studying her. The tension only resolves when he stops listening to the marker of her class and starts listening to her.

Do different regions or social classes have distinct ways of speaking?

"Proper" vs. "common" speech, court language vs. street language, regional dialect vs. capital standard. What does the way someone speaks reveal about where they're from and where they stand?

Protagonist's Speech

Speech patterns reveal history. Does their accent betray origins they try to hide, or signal status they want others to recognise?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Accent/dialect	
What it reveals about their background	
How the love interest perceives it (attraction, suspicion, fascination)	

Love Interest's Speech

How does their speech mark them in your world, and what does the protagonist notice about it that others might miss?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Accent/dialect	

ASPECT	DETAILS
What it reveals about their background	
How the protagonist perceives it (attraction, suspicion, fascination)	

Does either character code-switch — and what does the shift reveal?

Code-switching — changing how you speak depending on context — reveals which version of themselves a character shows to whom. The moment your love interest hears the “real” voice, the one reserved for home or for unguarded moments, is an intimacy milestone.

CHARACTER	"PUBLIC" VOICE (FORMAL, GUARDED)	"PRIVATE" VOICE (UNGUARDED, REAL)	WHAT TRIGGERS THE SWITCH	WHEN THE OTHER FIRST HEARS THE REAL VOICE
<i>Jude (The Cruel Prince)</i>	<i>Perfect, formal Fae court speech — sharper and more precise than any human's</i>	<i>Blunt, human-cadence English with her sisters — shorter sentences, more emotion</i>	<i>Danger, exhaustion, being caught off guard by Cardan</i>	<i>Cardan hears her swear in human idiom during a fight — it delights him because it's the first crack in her performance</i>
Protagonist				

CHARACTER	"PUBLIC" VOICE (FORMAL, GUARDED)	"PRIVATE" VOICE (UNGUARDED, REAL)	WHAT TRIGGERS THE SWITCH	WHEN THE OTHER FIRST HEARS THE REAL VOICE
Love interest				

When does one character hear the other's "real" voice?

When the careful accent slips, when they speak unguarded:

YOUR ANSWER

Silence, Lies & What Goes Unsaid

The most significant form of communication is sometimes what isn't communicated. Silence, lies, and evasion are all forms of language, and in romance they carry enormous weight. In many cases, what your characters choose not to communicate may be more telling than anything they do say.

What Goes Unsaid

What do your characters not say to each other?

What truths are they avoiding? What feelings go unexpressed?

CHARACTER	WHAT THEY DON'T SAY
Protagonist doesn't say	
Love interest doesn't say	

Why don't they say it?

Fear? Pride? Protection? Timing? Not having the words?

YOUR ANSWER

What does their silence communicate?

Can the other person feel what's not being said?

YOUR ANSWER

What does silence mean between your characters?

Comfortable silence signals safety. Tense silence signals unspoken desire or unresolved conflict. Both are scenes worth writing.

TYPE OF SILENCE	WHEN IT HAPPENS	WHAT IT COMMUNICATES
Comfortable silence		
Tense silence		
Silence mistaken for rejection		

In *Twilight*, Bella's mind is the only one Edward can't read, and that silence creates the sole motivation behind his obsession with her. Her unknowability levels a power dynamic that would otherwise be hopelessly lopsided. In *From Blood and Ash*, Poppy's entire identity as the Maiden is built on enforced

silence: she is not allowed to be physically touched or spoken to. When Hawke finally breaks through that silence, each word between them carries the weight of having transgressed against the rules of her role as the Maiden.

When does the unsaid finally get said?

The moment when they finally speak the truth they've been holding:

YOUR ANSWER

Lying & Evasion

Everyone lies in their own way, and in romance, how someone lies reveals as much as how they love. In *The Cruel Prince*, the Fae can't technically lie, therefore Cardan learns to use truth as a tool of war. When he tells Jude he thinks of her "often" and finds it "disgusting," every word is technically honest, but the way he frames those words disguises his vulnerability from being exposed in his hostility. Casteel's complete deception in *From Blood and Ash* is that he creates an entirely new identity as "Hawke" to get close to Poppy. The romance isn't ruined by the lie. It's complicated by the fact that all of the feelings he had were genuine, even though he was lying about who he claimed to be.

How does each character lie?

Deflection, omission, confident falsehood, nervous tells:

CHARACTER	HOW THEY LIE
Protagonist	

CHARACTER	HOW THEY LIE
Love interest	

How can they tell when the other is lying?

What tells give them away? Learning someone's tells is its own form of intimacy.

CHARACTER	THEIR TELLS
Protagonist's tells	
Love interest's tells	

When does one catch the other in a lie?

The moment of discovering a lie is significant. How much does the discovery cost the relationship, and what does the decision to either confront or not confront it reveal about each of them? In *The Wicked King*, Cardan sends Jude away with a decree that sounds like betrayal but contains a hidden loophole: as High Queen, she has the power to pardon herself. The romantic tension survives because decoding the literalism of his speech becomes Jude's act of faith in a man who communicates love through legal technicalities.

ASPECT	DETAILS
What was the lie	
How they knew	
What happened	

What truths are hard to say?

What's true but difficult to speak aloud?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a moment of radical honesty?

When all defences drop and they tell the whole truth:

YOUR ANSWER

Overhearing

Sometimes we gain insight into others' worlds through overheard words. Words heard in passing are very different to those intended as part of a conversation. They can confirm fears, offer unexpected hope, or create devastating misunderstandings.

Colin tells his brothers in *Bridgerton* that he would never marry Penelope, a revelation she discovers by accident, one which influences how she will perceive herself for years to come and further adds to the pining and resentment that exists in their later relationship. Poppy's eavesdropping at the Red Pearl leads directly to her first encounter with Hawke in *From Blood and Ash*, creating a romantic relationship that will forever be tied to her pursuit of truth about the world she has been sheltered from.

Does either character overhear something significant?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Who overhears	
What they hear	

ASPECT	DETAILS
Who was speaking (and to whom)	

How does what they overhear change things?

Does it reveal truth? Create misunderstanding? Confirm fears? Offer hope?

YOUR ANSWER

Does the speaker know they were overheard?

The asymmetry of knowledge creates tension. Does the listener reveal what they know, or carry it as a secret?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there something one character says about the other when they think they're not listening?

Defence of them to others? Confession of feelings? Criticism? Praise?

YOUR ANSWER

Learning to Read Each Other

Beyond words, there's a deeper layer of communication: learning to interpret each other. This is where the real intimacy lives. When two people know each other well enough to speak without speaking, it signals a bond that goes beyond anything language can carry. If your protagonist can read the love interest's mood from across a crowded room, or catches a micro-expression no one else would notice, readers feel the depth of that connection.

Nonverbal fluency develops slowly, though. At the start of their relationship, your characters will misread each other constantly. They'll project their own fears onto the love interest, miss signals, and assume silence is rejection when in fact it's just restraint. As the relationship deepens, they start catching the small things. That's the progression worth tracking.

NONVERBAL CUE	WHAT IT SIGNALS IN ROMANCE	WHEN IT MATTERS MOST
Jaw tightening, hands fisting	Anger held in check, restraint	When one is protecting the other from their own rage
Eyes dropping to lips, then away	Desire they're trying not to act on	Slow-burn tension before the first kiss
Shoulders dropping, breath releasing	Trust, safety, letting their guard down	The first time they feel safe with the other person
Micro-flinch at a word or topic	Hidden wound, painful history	When the other notices what no one else does
Smile that doesn't reach the eyes	Performance, hiding pain	When one character sees through the mask
Unconscious mirroring	Growing connection they haven't admitted	Subtle sign for the reader before the characters catch on

NONVERBAL CUE	WHAT IT SIGNALS IN ROMANCE	WHEN IT MATTERS MOST
Touch that lingers a beat too long	Wanting more than they'll say	The space between friendship and something else

What expressions or gestures does the protagonist learn to read in the love interest?

The small signs of their moods, needs, feelings. What do they notice first, and what takes months to decode?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the love interest learn to read in the protagonist?

The small signs only they notice, the tells that reveal mood, need, or hidden feeling beneath a composed surface. What makes them the only person who can read the protagonist accurately?

YOUR ANSWER

Do they develop private signals?

Looks across the room, small gestures, touches that mean something specific. Private signals are the nonverbal equivalent of a private language: proof that these two people have built a world between them that no one else can enter.

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a moment when one understands the other without any words at all?

A look that communicates everything. This is often one of the most powerful scenes in a romance, the moment when words become unnecessary:

YOUR ANSWER

How They Argue

Conflict reveals character. The way your characters fight tells readers more about the relationship than a dozen tender scenes. A fight takes away the politeness and pretences and leaves us with the raw truth of how these two people relate.

The most effective romantasy arguments do triple duty: they escalate the external plot (politics, war, secrets), they renegotiate relational terms (trust, autonomy, “what do we owe each other?”), and they intensify desire by making vulnerability legible under pressure. If your argument only does one of those things, it’s probably not pulling enough weight.

What Makes a Romantasy Argument Land

The strongest fights in the genre share a handful of craft patterns worth studying.

Build fights around conflicting goods, not good vs. evil. The most compelling arguments aren’t “one person is correct.” They’re “two values collide.” Survival vs. autonomy in ACOTAR’s Under the Mountain bargain. Secrecy-for-safety vs. truth-for-agency in *Fourth Wing*. Cruelty-as-mask vs. dignity-as-need in *The Cruel Prince*. Each character’s position in the fight should be defensible by a reasonable person given their constraints.

The unsayable line is a reclassification, not an insult. The strongest unsayable lines in romantasy rename the other person as a category. Cardan tells Jude that “mortal” means “born to die,” reducing her to a disposable species. Poppy calls Casteel “the Dark One,” locking him into enemy-myth. In ACOTAR’s pregnancy reveal, the unsayable moment is Feyre realising her body became a shared secret: “You... all of you knew this?” These lines work because they don’t just wound feelings. They change the power map of the relationship. An unsayable line changes the relationship dynamics of the people involved.

Repair comes through action, not apology. Across these series, repair is almost never delivered as “I’m sorry.” It arrives as behaviour: healing the arm, choosing not to kill, removing ambiguity about allegiance, offering a truth that costs status, returning agency. Early on in *Fourth Wing*, Violet and Xaden have some “repair” and it’s just that he doesn’t kill her on the parapet. In ACOTAR, the emotional repair from the bargain is pushed off until after a whole series of books and only comes from revealing why he did what he did and changing who he is. If your apology scene feels flat, try this: have your apologising character say only five words. Everything else must be action.

Cardan asks Jude to tell him she hates him during an intimate moment in *The Wicked King*, and she does so, repeating it over and over. This is a flip on the typical romantic conversation where “I love you” is the end goal. In their world, “I hate you” is the only safe way to acknowledge an all-consuming passion. Their arguments aren’t failures of communication. They’re a private code of hostility that only they truly understand.

Violet uses the psychic connection as a tool during conflict in *Fourth Wing*, sending distracting images to Xaden to punish him for emotionally withdrawing from their relationship. Once verbal communication stops working, they find ways to express their anger through other avenues. The question isn’t whether your characters fight. It’s what tools they reach for when words aren’t enough.

The Sound of an Argument on the Page

What your arguments *sound* like on the page matters as much as what gets said. Romantasy’s best fights typically occur with longer lines (which are often calmer) and more complexly constructed syntax. As anger or fear escalates, sentences compress into fragments, repetition, and rhetorical questions. Cardan’s “It means... It means...” is a great example of anaphora. Feyre’s “You... all of you knew this?” uses the ellipsis to enact shock in real time. First-person romantasy can also be written with internal beats becoming shorter and tighter (“Wait.” “No.”) as the character’s options narrow.

Draft the shape of an argument between your characters.

You don’t need to write full dialogue yet. Map how the rhythm changes. Start with what they’re saying calmly, then note where sentences start to compress.

PHASE	WHAT'S BEING SAID	HOW IT SOUNDS ON THE PAGE
<i>Controlled — the argument begins</i>	<i>“You had no right to make that decision without me.”</i>	<i>Full sentences, measured, each word deliberate</i>
Escalating — emotion breaks through		

PHASE	WHAT'S BEING SAID	HOW IT SOUNDS ON THE PAGE
Breaking point — the unsayable line		
Aftermath — silence, exit, or collapse		

What does conflict sound like between them?

Do they yell? Go cold? Talk in circles? Walk away? Get cutting? Cry?

CHARACTER	IN CONFLICT THEY...
Protagonist	
Love interest	

What words wound?

What can one say that truly hurts the other? Knowing what wounds someone is intimate knowledge, and using it is a betrayal of that intimacy. The strongest unsayable lines attack identity (“born to die”), belonging (“you are nothing”), or agency (“we decided for you”). Which of these would hurt your characters most?

CHARACTER	WORDS THAT WOUND THEM
Protagonist	
Love interest	

A Fight They Have

Real conflict reveals character. What triggers it, what gets said that can't be unsaid, and how does the aftermath shape them?

ASPECT	DETAILS
What it's about (the surface)	
What it's really about (the subtext)	
What gets said that can't be unsaid	

ASPECT	DETAILS
How it ends	

How do they repair after conflict?

The strongest repairs in romantasy are actions, not words. What does your character do that speaks louder than “I’m sorry”?

ASPECT	PROTAGONIST'S REPAIR	LOVE INTEREST'S REPAIR
The action (what they do, not what they say)		
What it costs them to do it		
How the other recognises it as repair		
What it proves about them that words couldn't		

What do they learn about each other through conflict?

Arguments can deepen understanding as much as gentle moments. What truths emerge only when defences are down?

YOUR ANSWER

Literacy & the Written Word

Literacy is power, and in romantasy, power imbalances create tension. Who can read and who can't, who writes letters and who can't reply, who controls information and who's shut out. These are romantic stakes disguised as worldbuilding.

What does literacy look like in your world?

Who can read shapes who holds power — and who's shut out of it. A character who can't read a love letter, a treaty, or a warning is vulnerable in ways that go beyond the battlefield.

ASPECT	DETAILS
Writing systems (alphabets, pictographs, magical scripts)	
How common is literacy	
Who controls access to reading and writing	
What can't be communicated without literacy	

Can your characters read and write?

Literacy can be a source of power, shame, or connection. How does each character's relationship to written language shape their world?

CHARACTER	LITERACY LEVEL
Protagonist	
Love interest	

If one is literate and one isn't, how does this affect them?

Does the literate one teach? Is there a power imbalance? Shame? Practical problems? Teaching someone to read is as intimate as teaching them your language.

YOUR ANSWER

Letters & Written Communication

Written words can be read and re-read; they can be hidden or rediscovered. A separation created by pen and paper allows for confessions to occur at times when verbal conversation can't.

In *Romancing Mister Bridgerton*, Penelope's secret life as Lady Whistledown gives her a written voice that is sharp, biting, and powerful, everything her public wallflower persona is not. When Colin finds her journals and eventually learns it was her who wrote them, the tension shifts from romantic pursuit to a clash of egos: he realises he never truly knew the woman he'd spent years overlooking. A written self can be braver than a spoken self, and the space between the page and the person is nothing but fuel for the fire of romance.

Do your characters exchange letters or written messages?

Written words can be reread, hidden, and discovered. A letter allows for confessions that spoken conversation can't — and creates physical evidence of feeling that can be found by the wrong person.

YOUR ANSWER

Map a letter or written exchange between your characters.

ASPECT	DETAILS
What they write	
What they can say in writing that they can't say aloud	
How it reaches the other person	
What risk exists in this being written down	

ASPECT	DETAILS
How the recipient reacts	

What do they write that they couldn't say?

What truths emerge only in writing?

YOUR ANSWER

Magical Communication

Magical communication offers an incredible advantage in terms of overcoming barriers; these include language, distance, privacy. But that shortcut comes with its own costs and complications. When your characters communicate directly to each other by means of their minds, it produces instant and overwhelming intimacy. This type of communication also brings with it the opportunity for eavesdropping: nothing is private if someone else can intercept your thoughts.

Here's the design principle worth remembering: romantic tension rises when a channel is high-intimacy, partially uncontrollable, and imperfectly private. This combination forces writers into writing scenes that are more about establishing boundaries and less about providing information. A telepathic bond where one character can't control what bleeds through is more interesting than one with perfect on/off control. A journal that could be stolen is far more interesting than one that's perfectly secure. Choose the method that creates the most friction between closeness and safety.

The choice of method will affect the overall romantic dynamic between your characters. Pick the one that serves the emotional arc you're building.

METHOD	ROMANTIC DYNAMIC IT CREATES	COMMON COST/ LIMITATION
Telepathy / mind-speech	Instant, overwhelming intimacy. No hiding. Thoughts bleed through before they can be filtered. In <i>ACOTAR</i> , Rhysand's daemati link with Feyre creates a private language that excludes the entire world, heightening the "us against them" dynamic. Feyre lowering her mental walls becomes the strongest indicator of love in the series.	Requires proximity, drains energy, or can't be controlled (accidental thought-sharing)

METHOD	ROMANTIC DYNAMIC IT CREATES	COMMON COST/ LIMITATION
Dream-walking	Intimate, surreal, emotionally raw. Characters meet in a space that feels unreal, which makes honesty easier. In <i>Strange the Dreamer</i> , the romance between Lazlo and Sarai is built entirely through dream-sharing before they can touch in waking life: intimacy before embodiment. The dream space makes recognition possible where reality wouldn't allow it.	Only works during sleep; hard to verify if it was real; vulnerability of being found in dreams. Dreams can also be manipulated, making them the highest-misunderstanding channel.
Enchanted objects (mirrors, journals, coins)	Tangible, keepable, rereadable. The object itself becomes precious, a third presence in the relationship that gets carried, hidden, touched, and protected. Unlike telepathy, which leaves no trace, a journal entry is proof of devotion, and losing the object becomes a credible emotional catastrophe. In <i>ACOTAR</i> , the bargain tattoo functions as an enchanted object: a sensory organ	Can be lost, stolen, intercepted, or destroyed. Limited bandwidth. The object's magic may also have its own agenda, turning a romantic promise into a trap.

METHOD	ROMANTIC DYNAMIC IT CREATES	COMMON COST/ LIMITATION
	through which Rhysand can send physical feelings and see through Feyre's eyes. The second, hidden tattoo becomes a private communication channel during Feyre's spy mission.	
Magical bonds (soul bonds, mating bonds)	Involuntary, inescapable. Emotions or sensations bleed across the bond whether wanted or not. In <i>Fourth Wing</i> , the dragon-mated bond between Violet and Xaden creates sensory overload during intimate moments and involuntary truth-sharing. Xaden's feelings bleed into Violet's consciousness even when he refuses to voice them aloud. In <i>ACOTAR</i> , the mating bond can signal injury, absence, or death: when the bond goes silent, it means the worst has happened.	Loss of privacy, inability to hide pain or desire, bond may be unwanted initially. Bonds can be rejected but rarely erased; the "tug" persists, which means romance must be negotiated inside a permanent system rather than chosen fresh.
Sending spells / magical letters	Deliberate, one-directional. The sender chooses words carefully, like a letter but instant. In <i>Divine Rivals</i> , Iris	Can be intercepted, traced, or blocked. Asynchrony means misunderstandings can't be quickly repaired.

METHOD	ROMANTIC DYNAMIC IT CREATES	COMMON COST/ LIMITATION
	slips letters beneath her wardrobe door and they vanish into the hands of her rival, Roman. They fall in love as anonymous correspondents before they can admit it face to face: the classic pattern of loving a mind before a body.	The same secrecy that makes letters romantic makes them dangerous.
Animal messengers / familiars	Indirect, charming, limited. The messenger adds personality and constraint.	Slow, unreliable, limited message length. The animal may have its own agenda.

What magical communication methods exist in your world?

Telepathy? Sending spells? Magical mirrors? Dream-walking? Enchanted objects?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Method	
How it works	
Limitations	

ASPECT	DETAILS
Who has access	
What romantic tension it creates	

Do your characters use magical communication?

Magical methods can create instant connection or bypass barriers, but they may also be monitored, traced, or come with their own costs.

ASPECT	DETAILS
Which method	
When they use it	

Is magical communication private, or can it be intercepted?

The belief that communication is private changes what people say. What happens if that privacy is an illusion?

YOUR ANSWER

What can they say magically that they can't say aloud?

When magic provides a private channel, what becomes possible? Confessions in the dark, words across distance, thoughts too dangerous to speak.

YOUR ANSWER

Sacred, Secret & Forbidden Languages

Restricted languages carry power. Knowing a forbidden tongue can mark someone as chosen, criminal, or dangerous. And in romance, sharing a language no one else speaks creates the ultimate private space. Teaching someone a forbidden language is an act of trust that can't be taken back.

Are there languages that are sacred, secret, or forbidden?

A language no one else speaks is the ultimate private space. If your characters share access to a restricted tongue, they carry a secret that binds them — and that can endanger them both.

ASPECT	DETAILS
Name/type	
Who can speak it	
Why it's special	

Is there a magical language?

Required for spells? A language of power? A language belonging to a particular species or order?

YOUR ANSWER

Does either character teach the other a sacred or forbidden language?

What does sharing this knowledge mean? What risk does it carry?

YOUR ANSWER

True Names

True names that have real power exist everywhere in fantasy. If you're using this concept, think about what makes your version distinctive. When you give someone your true name, it means ultimate vulnerability. It says *I trust you with power over me*.

In *From Blood and Ash*, this plays out through identity rather than magic. Poppy falls in love with "Hawke," then she has to come to terms with loving "Casteel," then earns the intimacy of "Cas." Each name represents a slightly different version of the same man, and Poppy's experience moving from each name is a metaphor for her journey towards fully understanding the entire man behind all his masks.

Do true names have power in your world?

What kind of power? Control, magical access, bond creation, vulnerability?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your true name system differ from the familiar versions?

What's unique about how it works in your world?

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters have true names different from their common names?

What would it mean for your protagonist to share, or withhold, this from their love interest?

CHARACTER	TRUE NAME	WHAT IT MEANS/WHY IT MATTERS
Protagonist		

CHARACTER	TRUE NAME	WHAT IT MEANS/WHY IT MATTERS
Love interest		

When does one learn the other's true name?

This moment marks a turning point. Is it freely given or discovered? What changes when this knowledge passes between them?

ASPECT	DETAILS
The moment of revelation	
What it means for their relationship	

Names, Address & Private Language

The way characters address each other is a map of their relationship. Titles become first names become nicknames become private words only they use. Every shift in address marks a shift in intimacy, and readers feel it.

Forms of Address

What forms of address exist?

Titles, honorifics, and familiar names create layers of intimacy. The shift from formal to informal often marks a relationship’s evolution.

TYPE	EXAMPLES
Formal (titles, honorifics)	
Informal (first names, common address)	
Intimate (pet names, private names)	

What shift in how they address each other marks growing intimacy?

From title to name? Formal to informal? Surname to given name? A private nickname? In *From Blood and Ash*, the progression from “Hawke” to “Casteel” to “Cas” tracks Poppy’s journey from loving a persona, to confronting a stranger, to accepting the real man. Each name marks a different stage of the relationship, and the moment she chooses “Cas” is the moment the deception stops mattering more than the person beneath it.

ASPECT	DETAILS
Initial address	

ASPECT	DETAILS
Intimate address	
When the shift happens	

Code, Cipher & Private Language

The inside joke, the glance that holds meaning, the word or phrase that only one person will get. Private language marks a unique bond. This is essentially the verbal equivalent of a locked door: all others remain outside.

In *The Cruel Prince*, Jude and Cardan’s shared cruelty functions as a private code. The insults they give one another serve as a language of fixation that only they understand; when Cardan says to Queen Orlagh that he will have Jude, it may appear to be a political statement for those around them, but Jude understands this to be a desperate expression of his personal desire. The daemati link in *ACOTAR* serves the same function: a channel that excludes the entire world and belongs only to Feyre and Rhysand.

Do your characters develop a code or private language?

ASPECT	DETAILS
<i>What form it takes</i>	<i>Insults that are actually terms of endearment — Jude and Cardan’s mutual cruelty functions as a private love language only they decode</i>
<i>What they can say in code that they can’t say openly</i>	<i>“I hate you” means “I can’t stop thinking about you” — the cruelty is the only safe container for obsession</i>
<i>When they first use it</i>	<i>Their first real verbal sparring match, when Jude realises Cardan’s hostility is fixation, not indifference</i>

ASPECT	DETAILS
What form it takes	
What they can say in code that they can't say openly	
When they first use it	

Words for Love

Endearments carry cultural weight. Are they common or reserved? What does using, or avoiding, such words reveal about your characters and their world?

What words express love or affection in your world's languages?

TYPE	EXAMPLES
<i>Common terms of endearment</i>	<i>"Darling" in ACOTAR — used broadly among the Fae, but Rhysand's use of it for Feyre shifts from teasing to genuine across the series</i>
<i>More intimate or private words</i>	<i>"Mate" — a word that carries biological, magical, and emotional weight; not used casually</i>
Common terms of endearment	

TYPE	EXAMPLES
More intimate or private words	

Are there words for love in one language that don't exist in another?

Concepts that can't quite be translated. These untranslatable words become story in themselves.

YOUR ANSWER

What's the first affectionate thing one says in the other's language?

Learning to say something tender in someone else's tongue is an act of reaching across distance.

ASPECT	DETAILS
The word/phrase	
How the other reacts	

If they say "I love you," in what language?

Whose language and why that choice:

YOUR ANSWER

Misunderstanding & Clarity

Misunderstanding is one of the oldest tools in romance, and one of the easiest to get wrong. A great misunderstanding has to feel inevitable based on the nature of the two characters. If a reader thinks that a misunderstanding could easily be resolved by a single honest statement, then it will appear contrived. But if the misunderstanding grows from a real language gap, a cultural difference, or a character flaw that makes them interpret things through the wrong lens, it becomes genuinely painful and satisfying to watch unfold.

The best misunderstandings aren't just about getting the words wrong. They're about getting the *meaning* wrong because of who the characters are.

MISUNDERSTANDING TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT RESOLVES IT
Literal translation error	A word or phrase means something different than expected	Learning the real meaning, often too late or at exactly the right moment
Cultural misread	A gesture or custom means something different in each culture	Someone explains, or the character figures it out through observation
Tone lost in translation	Sarcasm, affection, or formality doesn't translate	Hearing the same words spoken with feeling, not just translated
Overheard fragment	Hearing part of a conversation and filling in the gaps wrong	Learning the full context, often after acting on the wrong assumption
Deliberate misdirection	A third party translates or explains incorrectly on purpose	The truth comes out and the manipulator is exposed

MISUNDERSTANDING TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT RESOLVES IT
Silence read as rejection	One character's inability to speak is taken as unwillingness	The moment when they finally find the words, or find another way

What misunderstanding occurs because of language barriers?

Language gaps create room for confusion, comedy, or heartbreak. What gets lost in translation between your characters, and is the misunderstanding rooted in language, culture, or character?

ASPECT	DETAILS
The miscommunication	
Why it's inevitable given who these characters are	
What each character believes happened	
How it's resolved	

When do they finally understand each other completely?

Not just words, but meaning. This moment often lands near the emotional climax of the romance, when all the barriers, linguistic and otherwise, finally come down:

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check

QUESTION	ANSWER	BOOK EXAMPLE
How does language reflect cultural values (from Section 3)?		In <i>The Cruel Prince</i> , Fae inability to lie shapes an entire culture of strategic wordplay and technical truths
What's the official/legal language (from Section 5)?		In <i>ACOTAR</i> , magical contracts must be written in High Fae to be binding, making language a legal instrument
How does language interact with magic (from Part 1)?		In <i>Fourth Wing</i> , dragon bonds create involuntary psychic communication that bypasses spoken language entirely
How do language barriers intersect with political power?		In <i>Bridgerton</i> , Sophie's refined accent simultaneously reveals her noble blood and endangers her servant disguise

Quick Reference: Language Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
Protagonist speaks	
Love interest speaks	
Common ground	
The translator (if needed)	
The first word learned	
What goes unsaid	

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
How they argue	
Private communication method	
The shift in address (from → to)	
The true name revelation (if applicable)	

Final Thought

Language barriers cause people to use different means to connect: by their actions, through their patience with one another, through the vulnerability of misunderstanding. But language is also what's not said. Silence. Lies. Truths too heavy to speak. The way someone's voice sounds when they say your name.

Learning someone's language is an act of investment. It says: *your world matters enough for me to learn how you see it*. So build language that creates both barriers and bridges. Make your characters work to understand each other, and make that work meaningful.

Each word they teach each other, each silence they share, each shift from formal to intimate should mark a deepening connection. Don't just have them speak the same language. Make them *learn* each other.